



Tog on Interface

A fun and highly entertaining book by Bruce Tognazzini on interface design if you want to know the basics of the subject and don't want to get bored by a text book

Hotel with a view for all

Designer Richard Hywel Evans has designed a three storey building, 61 meters in diameter that is placed on a very slow moving continuous turntable rotating 1.3 times per day

it, it imposes a huge set of demands which the product should adhere to during all the stages of its existence. With many of these demands being contradictory, it becomes a trade off by favouring some the product's attributes over the lesser ones. "For example putting in extra components and tightly packaging the product to miniaturize it might make it difficult to service it, or replace parts later, and even create problems in recycling the components," says Himanshu.

Besides, designers in different countries face different challenges. "In India, design awareness is still at a nascent stage. However, a designer having a tiff with engineers from R&D on grounds of techno-aesthetic feasibility is quite normal, regular and universal. Designers

moving, says in a video on videojug.com "The number one is communication. I think most product designers really outsource their marketing, copy, branding and packaging. They design a product and then they shot gun it out to thirty people and you have just too many voices which creates noise and clutter. What the product designer really needs to do is not only be a product designer, but also be able to communicate what his product does for the consumer. And being a product designer in the green space, you know what I've learned is that communicating green is you have to be very specific about your impact. Generalities do not work for the green people. A perfect example, is when we started renting boxes, we had customers



Eskild Hansen, Head of the European Design Center at Cisco

"Designers have moved up from concept design and aesthetics to something much more strategic such as innovation and understanding users in a new way"

always work with non-standards and create new procedures and processes which at times become difficult to reason out to people with rational thinking," says Sandip.

Economic viability is a very pertinent concern for designers. "One of the major challenges faced by designers is keeping a product under budget given the technology and manufacturing constraints while trying to match the vision that marketing has for the product. For instance, a designer might propose that glass is a suitable material as against acrylic for a particular use. But it may happen that the manufacturing process incorporating glass might slowdown production speeds or increase expenditure. So a designer has to constantly evaluate his design based on the budget so that he delivers the best given the money", says Nithin David, an independent industrial design professional.

For an independent designer communicating your message correctly is as important as the product itself. This is true especially for designers working in the green space. As Spencer Brown, founder and inventor, earth friendly

that would say "What's your carbon offset? What's your carbon footprint? How much energy is used to produce this box"? You'd better have those answers. If you design a product and you're going to design a green product, you're also going to need to be open and transparent in your work. If you're not transparent and if you're not going to share the impact in specifics, you're going to get crucified. Don't show up."

Where are we now and where is design headed in the future?

Design has evolved quite a bit over the years. First the focus was on automation, then it moved on to speed and finally design. Now we see a whole new direction from intuitive designs to products becoming green. Let's look at what experts have to say on some of these trends.

Going green

The design life of a component or product is defined as the period of time during which the item is expected by its designers to work within its specified parameters; in other words, the life

IDEO

one of the world's leading design firms, predicted these design trends for the future

- Ever-increasing simplicity
- Diagnostic everything
- Mobile and wireless everything
- Virtual prototyping interactions and living
- Context awareness
- Sensors everywhere
- Your identity everywhere
- Smart surfaces
- Data visualisation
- Deliberate hackability and open-source-ness
- Peer-to-Peer
- Mashups
- Co-created everything
- Body hacking
- Radical transparency
- Collaborative innovation
- Techno collective action

expectancy of the product. "Designers can be seen as creating for the next landfill meaning that products become obsolete very quickly. Originally, products were designed to be kept for a long period of time and now a days, things are discarded in months," says Hayley. Hence designers have a choice about whether to design for longevity or design to make way for the "new and improved" version of the same product. Here many corporate considerations also come into play. "Design is also about the experience the product gives. This includes packaging, so in our little way, we do our bit by say instead of having a book inside can we print as much of the information on the box itself, thereby saving paper. Being in the field of technology, things change fast. If you look at your cell phone from three years ago, it's no longer relevant. Still, what we strive to do gives higher quality products, so even though people would keep our products for a longer time, we have a better position in the market," said Eskild from Cisco.

Some designers like Nithin David believe going green is "only a 'story' that can be used to sell design, while being responsible for the environment." He says "In the future, I expect material usage, etc to be regulated by governments trying to reduce the impact of industry on the ecosystem. Sustainable products are important and that is the way forward for any product manufacturer in the future."

Micro vs. Macro trends